

Russian, Step by Step, Root by Root

A gentle, etymology-driven introduction to Russian

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Starter edition — two cumulative chapters of short lessons.

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in Noto Sans (SIL Open Font License).

Preface

This book teaches Russian one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It assumes no Russian and no Cyrillic. Every section takes one small expression, introduces only the letters, sounds, or grammar that expression needs, connects it to history you may already know, and ends by asking for it back.

Russian is a Slavic language, a cousin of English far enough back that the family resemblance survives in surprising places — *three* is *tri*, *sister* is *sestrá* — and it is worth knowing which resemblances are real and which are traps. This book flags both.

Stress matters enormously in Russian, and ordinary Cyrillic does not print it. So the romanization here marks the stressed vowel with an acute accent, and then gradually yields to the script as you come to read it.

This is a starter edition: two chapters, complete in themselves, with more being written.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Russian out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart.

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Contents

Preface	iii
1 Greetings and courtesy	1
1.1 привет (<i>privét</i>) — informal hello	1
1.2 здравствуйте (<i>zdrávstvuyte</i>) — formal hello	2
1.3 спасибо (<i>spasíbo</i>) — thank you	2
1.4 да (<i>da</i>) — yes	3
1.5 нет (<i>nyet</i>) — no, literally not-is	3
1.6 пожалуйста (<i>pozhalústa</i>) — please and you are welcome . .	4
1.7 Chapter 1 retrieval — choose the register	5
2 Introducing yourself	7
2.1 я (<i>ya</i>) — I	7
2.2 ты, вы (<i>ty, vy</i>) — two forms of you	8
2.3 меня зовут ... (<i>menyá zovút ...</i>) — my name is	8
2.4 Ask a name	9
2.5 очень приятно (<i>óchen priyátno</i>) — pleased to meet you . .	10
2.6 A complete formal introduction	10
2.7 The informal switch	11
A note on sources	13

Chapter 1

Greetings and courtesy

This chapter grows a complete courtesy exchange from six expressions. Cyrillic arrives inside each word, starting with the four letters that most often fool a Latin-alphabet reader. Companion lessons: RU-C01-*.md.

1.1 привет (*privét*) — informal hello

Read only what this expression needs

Read left to right. In **привет**, **п** says *p*, **р** says *r*, **и** says “ee,” **в** says *v*, **е** begins with a light “ye,” and **т** says *t*. Two shapes lie to a Latin-trained eye: **р** looks like *p* but says *r*; **в** looks like *B* but says *v*. Stress the final syllable: *pri-VYET*.

Where the expression came from

Privét contains the old *vet-* family associated with speaking, news, and counsel. The same family is visible in **совет** *sovét*, a council or piece of advice — the word behind the international name *Soviet*. A greeting and a council both begin with words exchanged.

Use it now

Use **привет** with a friend, child, or someone you already address informally. It is not the safest first word for a stranger in a formal setting.

One-minute checkpoint

Which two letters are false friends? Point to **р** and say *r*; point to **в** and say *v*. Then read **привет** once with final stress.

1.2 здравствуйте (*zdrávstvuyte*) — formal hello

Read only what this expression needs

This long word is learned as a sound shape before every letter is writable. Aim first for *ZDRAST-vuy-tye*: everyday speech compresses the central cluster and the first written **В** is often not heard. Stress stays near the front. Recognizing a contraction is enough; perfect consonant gymnastics are not.

Where the expression came from

здравствуйте is historically an instruction: “be healthy.” Its core is **здрав-**, the health family also visible in **здоровье** “health.” The ending **-те** is plural and also polite, so the word carries respect in its grammar as well as goodwill in its root.

Use it now

Use **здравствуйте** with a stranger, an older person, a professional contact, or a group. Contrast only the register: **привет** informal; **здравствуйте** polite or plural.

One-minute checkpoint

What wish hides inside the formal greeting? “Be healthy.” Which ending helps make it polite? **-те**. Choose the formal greeting for a new teacher.

1.3 спасибо (*spasíbo*) — thank you

Read only what this expression needs

Reuse **с** *s*, another false friend because it looks like Latin *C*. The stress is in the middle: *spa-SEE-ba*. The final written **о** is unstressed and reduces toward an *a*-like sound. Russian spelling preserves the word while speech weakens the vowel.

Where the expression came from

спасибо wore down from **спаси Бог**: “God save [you].” English *good-bye* grew from “God be with ye,” and Spanish *adiós* points “to God.”

Different languages turned short blessings into ordinary social words; modern *spasibo* is simply “thank you.”

Use it now

Build a safe formal exchange: Здравствуйте! — Здравствуйте! — Спасибо. One greeting and one thanks are enough.

One-minute checkpoint

Where is the stress in спасибо? On *-si-*. What happens to final unstressed о? It sounds more *a*-like. Say *spa-SEE-ba*.

1.4 да (*da*) — yes

Read only what this expression needs

Two letters: **д** *d* and **а** *a* as in “father.” Neither is a false friend. Read **да** as one clear syllable.

Use it now

Да is a complete “yes.” Russian also uses it to keep a conversation moving, rather like “right” or “well,” but affirmative *da* is the only job due now.

One-minute checkpoint

Read **да**. Answer a harmless yes/no question with it once.

1.5 нет (*nyet*) — no, literally not-is

Read only what this expression needs

Н is the third major false friend: it looks like Latin *H* but says *n*. At the start of this word **е** carries a “ye” sound, then **т** gives *t*: *nyet*.

Where the expression came from

нет compresses an older combination of **не** “not” and a form of **есть** “is/exists”: roughly “there is not.” The negative *ne* goes back to Indo-European *ne, a deep relative of English *no*, *not*, *never*, and *nay*.

Use it now

Contrast complete answers only: **да** — yes; **нет** — no.

One-minute checkpoint

What sound does **н** make? Say *n*, then answer “no” with **нет**.

1.6 пожалуйста (*pozhalusta*) — please and you are welcome

Read only what this expression needs

Meet **ж**, the sound *zh* in English “measure.” The careful spelling is longer than ordinary speech: aim for *pa-ZHAL-sta*. Stress *-zhah-* and allow the middle syllable to contract after you can recognize the full word.

Where the expression came from

The word grew from **пожалуй**, a form connected with granting or doing a favour, plus the old particle **-ста**. That favour-history explains both modern jobs: a request can begin “please,” and a received thanks can be answered “you are welcome.”

Use it now

Ask with **пожалуйста**; answer **спасибо** with **пожалуйста**. Context chooses between “please” and “you are welcome.”

One-minute checkpoint

What new sound does **ж** carry? *Zh*. Answer **Спасибо** with **Пожалуйста**.

1.7 Chapter 1 retrieval — choose the register

Use it now

For a friend: Привет! For a stranger: Здравствуйте! Continue either exchange with Спасибо. — Пожалуйста. Then practise the answer pair Да. — Нет.

One-minute checkpoint

Without looking back, produce: informal hello, formal hello, thank you, you are welcome, yes, no. Now read the six Cyrillic forms in the same order.

Chapter 2

Introducing yourself

The first chapter supplied courtesy moves. This chapter adds pronouns, one naming construction, its matching question, and a complete first conversation. Case appears only through the forms the exchange needs. Companion lessons: RU-C02-*.md.

2.1 я (*ya*) — I

Read only what this expression needs

я looks like a mirrored Latin *R*, but it is a vowel letter pronounced “ya.” Learn the whole word and letter together: я means “I.” Do not copy the Latin sound onto the Cyrillic shape.

Where the expression came from

First-person pronouns resist borrowing. Russian я continues Proto-Slavic *azŭ, from the ancient Indo-European pronoun family also behind Latin *ego*, German *ich*, and English *I*. The modern shapes differ dramatically because this tiny word has travelled inside each language for millennia.

One-minute checkpoint

What does я say and mean? “Ya, I.” Read it without calling it an *R*.

2.2 ТЫ, ВЫ (*ty, vy*) — two forms of you

Read only what this expression needs

Both words contain **Ы**, a vowel English lacks. Begin with the “ee” of *ill*, then draw the tongue slightly back. **ТЫ** is informal singular; **ВЫ** is plural or polite. The first letters are familiar **Т** *t* and the false friend **В** *v*.

Where the expression came from

English once kept a number and familiarity contrast in *thou* and *you*. Russian still distinguishes **ТЫ** and **ВЫ**. Polite plurals also appear in French *vous*; German formal *Sie* instead uses a third-person form, while Spanish *usted* grew from a title meaning “your grace.” Similar social work can arise through different grammar.

Use it now

Use **ТЫ** with one friend or child. Use **ВЫ** with a stranger, in a formal relationship, or with more than one person. When unsure with an adult stranger, begin with **ВЫ**.

One-minute checkpoint

Choose for one close friend: **ТЫ**. Choose for a new professor: **ВЫ**. Produce the unfamiliar vowel once without turning it into plain “ee.”

2.3 МЕНЯ ЗОВУТ ... (*menyá zovút ...*) — my name is ...

Read only what this expression needs

меня ends in the new **Я** sound; **зовут** reuses **В** *v* and **Т** *t*. Stress the final syllable of each part: *me-NYA zo-VOOT*. Insert the name after the verb: **Меня зовут Анна**.

Use it now

The literal pattern is “[they] call me Anna.” Russian supplies no separate word for “my” or “name” here. The plural verb **зовут** has an unnamed general subject — people call me — much like English “they say it will

rain.” Learn the frame, not a word-for-word English substitution.

Where the expression came from

Меня is the object form paired with subject **я**. English preserves a small version of this contrast in *I/me*; Russian case changes every noun and pronoun. No table is due: notice only that “I” and “me” have different shapes in both languages.

One-minute checkpoint

Does the Russian sentence contain a word for “name”? No. Replace Anna with your name and say **Меня зовут ...** once.

2.4 как вас зовут? (*kak vas zovút?*) — what is your name?

Read only what this expression needs

как is “how.” **вас** is the object form associated here with polite **вы**; **зовут** is unchanged from your answer. Russian asks literally: “How do they call you?”

Where the expression came from

Russian *kak*, French *comment*, and Spanish *cómo* all frame the naming question as “how.” English asks “what” because it treats the answer as a possessed name. The same social question can be organized around an action or a thing.

Use it now

Pair the question and answer: **Как вас зовут? — Меня зовут Анна.** Keep **зовут** exactly the same.

One-minute checkpoint

Which word asks “how”? **как**. Ask the polite question, then answer it with your name.

2.5 очень приятно (*óchen priyátno*) — pleased to meet you

Read only what this expression needs

очень is “very”; its final **ь** is a soft sign, which has no sound of its own but changes the consonant before it. **приятно** is “pleasant.” Read the phrase literally as “very pleasant.”

Where the expression came from

приятно belongs to a Slavic family of favour and affection, traced to Indo-European *preyH- “love, please.” Germanic used the same deep family for English *friend*, a person who is dear; the usual historical account also connects *free*. Russian and English preserve opposite branches of the same old idea.

Use it now

Russian needs no spoken “it is” in this present-tense expression: **Очень приятно.** literally “Very pleasant.” Use it after names are exchanged.

One-minute checkpoint

What does the soft sign pronounce by itself? Nothing. Say the literal two words, “very pleasant,” then the Russian phrase.

2.6 A complete formal introduction

Use it now

Read one turn at a time:

1. A: Здравствуйте!
2. B: Здравствуйте!
3. A: Как вас зовут?
4. B: Меня зовут Анна.
5. A: Очень приятно.

6. В: Спасибо.

Every expression is already known. Only their conversation order is new.

One-minute checkpoint

Cover the list. Rebuild the exchange from these cues: formal hello, ask a name, give a name, pleased to meet you, thank you.

2.7 The informal switch

Read only what this expression needs

Case gives the three pronouns different object forms: я “I” becomes **меня** “me”; ты becomes **тебя**; вы becomes **вас**. Learn these as three pairs, not as a complete case table.

Use it now

With one friend, replace **Здравствуйте** with **Привет** and ask **Как тебя зовут?** The answer stays **Меня зовут ...**; the verb **зовут** does not change.

One-minute checkpoint

Which two pieces change from the formal exchange? The greeting and the object pronoun: **Здравствуйте / вас** become **Привет / тебя**. Produce the informal question once.

A note on sources

Etymologies are traced against standard comparative sources for Slavic and Indo-European, and every English cousin claimed here is one the evidence actually supports. Where a resemblance is only a resemblance, the text says so rather than quietly banking it.